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Living with Bluetooth

I jumped onto the Bluetooth bandwagon a few weeks ago. I had been hearing about it for months. Of how Bluetooth removes the clutter of cables from your desktop; of how your computer, mobile phone and PDA can wirelessly synchronize with each other; of how a range of Bluetooth devices around your house, all using their low-power short-range communications abilities, would make the smart home a reality.

And yet, all of this was just potential, still untapped. Nobody has yet created a killer application that uses Bluetooth to do something fantastic that couldn't be done before. The best I came across was the ability to send and receive SMS messages from your desktop, and at over Rs 15,000 for a decent Bluetooth capable phone, that ability was totally not worth the price.

And then one likely candidate appeared. Salling Software's Sony Ericsson Clicker (SEC) for Mac OS X lets you program a menu on to your phone that executes scripts to control applications on your desktop. Use it to switch tracks on your media player, navigate through slides on your presentation, control your mouse and do just about anything that you can write a script for. I use an Apple PowerBook running Mac OS X. All I needed was a USB Bluetooth adapter from D-Link and a Sony Ericsson phone (other phones do not have programmable menu abilities of the SE phones). D-Link doesn't sell their USB Bluetooth adapter in India, but Nokia sells a Bluetooth kit for their 6210i phone which includes a PCMCIA Bluetooth adapter. But a quick Google search revealed that it didn't come with drivers for Mac OS X and third-party drivers cost more than I was willing to pay. So D-Link, it had to be, and I asked a friend visiting California to pick up one for me from the Apple store.

A week after he returned with my adapter, I got myself a Sony Ericsson T68i. Unlike IrDA, Bluetooth is omni-directional. You can't just point two phones at each other and beam your address card because the phone across the hall will also receive the transmission. Bluetooth therefore requires that devices authenticate with each other first, which I did. I can now point at a phone number in my address book and tell the phone to dial. When

an SMS arrives, I don't have to rummage around for the phone because the message is already showing on my screen, from where I can either save it, or send a reply. I can synchronize my address book and calendar with the phone so I don't have to maintain each separately. Using SEC's proximity sensor, I can have my computer stop playing music when I walk out of the room and start again when I return. When I make a presentation, I have the freedom to walk around and still switch slides without having to return to the laptop, and without needing a minion assigned to spacebar-duty.

A friend of mine who visited California happened to meet Steve "Woz" Wozniak of Apple fame there, and described to me how Woz uses Bluetooth. American cellular service company, Cingular, offers a scheme where you can get up to four phones in a family pack, and all communication between these four phones is free. Woz has two phones on this scheme. One sits at home connected to a DSL line, the other sits in his pocket with Bluetooth enabled. When Woz wants to get online, he uses his laptop to make a data connection over Bluetooth to the phone in his pocket, which in turn makes a data call to his phone back home, which is connected to a DSL line. Woz can get online from anywhere in the US without a phone line or a network connection, for free. To hell with all the hype about WiFi!

So if there are funky things that can be done with Bluetooth, why isn't everyone using it yet? Let's look at Woz's case again—Something like that isn't possible in India. Sure, Indian cellular providers have schemes for free calls between phones, but that doesn't include free data calls. If you want data at a reasonable speed, it'll cost you an arm and a leg, and Bluetooth is really all about data.

As it stands today, Bluetooth does little more than eliminate cables at a very high price. If you really want the benefits of the technology, you'll only get it with large scale adoption, and therein lies the dilemma. Unless prices drop significantly, technology users will not adopt it. And unless there is demand, prices will not drop. If a killer application appears, it could remedy the situation by making people more willing to pay, but no one has figured one out yet. ■

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